CONSUMING FIRE
MINISTRIES INTERNATIONAL

GUIIDELINES FOR YOUTH MINISTRY

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The purpose of this manual is to provide the vision, purpose, teaching and guidelines and procedures of CFMI Youth Department.

VISION STATEMENT

CFMI seeks to become the training ground with a holistic approach to spiritual growth of every young person of every ethnicity within reach of CFMI so that they are equipped with the resources necessary to enter young adulthood, living as disciples of Jesus Christ by realizing their full potential and making positive contributions to the Kingdom of God.

> *"But as for you, continue in what you have learned and have become convinced of, because you know those from whom you learned it, 15and how from infancy you have known the holy Scriptures, which are able to make you wise for salvation through faith in Christ Jesus."*
>
> 2 Timothy 3:14-15

VALUES

- We believe that every youth needs to have a personal relationship with God and after being taught can participate in the work of bringing the "un-churched" youths and even adults into a personal relationship with God.
- We believe that being a people-focused ministry will foster the personal development of the individual gifts of the youth, thus making it possible to drive young people towards spiritual maturity.
- We believe that every youth is loved by God and has greatness, potential, and great opportunities ahead and requires guidance and mentorship for them to discover who they are and maximize their potential.

WHAT IS YOUTHS MINISTRY?

CFMI recognizes youths in two groups. Youths from the age of twelve up to the age of nineteen are categorized as – **Teens or teenagers**. Age groups from zero years to eleven falls under **Children's ministry**. Age groups from twenty years and above, as long as they are single, both bachelors and spinsters are categorized as **Young Adults**.

WHY IS YOUTHS MINISTRY IMPORTANT?

"O God, You have taught me from my youth, And I still declare Your wondrous deeds. And even when I am old and gray, O God, do not forsake me, Until I declare Your strength to this generation, Your power to all who are to come."

Psalm 71:17,18

Throughout the Old Testament, the need to train the youth by the elderly is greatly emphasized (Prov 2:1; 3:1-8; 4:1-2; 5:1-2). It is important for the truth of the gospel to be passed down from generation to generation in order to grow the body of Christ. For this to be achieved, elderly people must transmit the gospel to the younger generation. We believe that children matter to God and we try to provide excellent, age-appropriate ministry programming for the children of the church, teenagers and young adults. Jesus said, "Let the children come to me, and do not hinder them, for the kingdom of God belongs to such as these" (Luke 18:16) God has commanded adults to train a child in the way he should go and when he is old he would not depart from it (Prov.22:6). Also, the exhortation God gives the youth to remember the Creator in the days of their youth (Eccl. 12:1) shows the importance of the youth ministry. The times we live in have changed and demand Gospel communicators to be like "the men of Issachar, who understood the times and knew what Israel should do" (2 Chron. 12:32).

THE PRIMARY ROLE OF YOUTHS ADVISORS

God does not call the equipped; He equips the called. That means no one has to be an expert. We do not expect our youth advisors to be perfect but we endaevour to give them basic instructions which by God's grace are useful in building and developing and mentoring CFMI youths. We require that the youth advisors must have the Bible as a yardstick for every program, plan, objective, and goal.

Youths advisors provide overall leadership for youth ministries including guidance and resources for all aspects of youth ministry.

Youth advisors provides training, resource evaluation or development & selection, and support for youth ministry programming, and assist youth ministry committee leaders with program planning and implementation.

Youths advisors are there to model, mentor, and equip these young ministers in Christ-like character, sound doctrine, and effective methods to reach their lost peers and make disciples for Christ (Matthew 28:18-20). Thus a youth advisor is supposed to win the lost youths, establish them in the faith, and equip them to serve.

Youths leaders should provide mentorship to all the youths in the Church. The Apostle Paul gives us a good picture of this kind of effective mentoring ministry in 2 Timothy 2:2 when he says to Timothy, "The things that you have heard from me in the presence of many witnesses, these entrust to faithful men who will be able to teach others also." Truths can be passed on from one person to the other.

THE CRISIS OF MODERN TIMES

Youth Ministry seems to be in the midst of a crisis, since it fails young people because of its inability to help them develop into mature Christians. There is a difference between adults and teens, sometimes called the "generation gap." Sociologists refer to this gap as an "intergenerational conflict." In the late 40's the term teenager was invented and the phrase "juvenile delinquent" was coined. The tension is also reflected in our society where teenagers have definite ideas and lifestyles, many times conflicting with their parents. Family tension is not restricted to non-Christians or to a certain segment of the country; family tension seems to be prevalent in all of society. The tension is also seen in local churches. Adults yearn for the "good ole days," while young people want their religion to be up to date.

Josh McDowell, referred by many as an authority on the mindset of contemporary youth, says that he can no longer say, **"the youth of today will be the church of tomorrow because if we do not do something now to educate our kids in the foundations of Christian faith, the young people we're counting on to lead the church to the next generation won't even be in the church."**

The youth of today is being bombarded every day by new information through social media, television, radio, satellite, internet and the school system. No longer does the young person want to know what's happening, be wants to be what's happening. Without proper guidance and power from God and His word, today's youths are in a great danger. They live in a world with so much information on one hand and on the other, so much ignorance. Our youth are confused about the truth. Their idea of distinction between right and wrong is fluid. Today's youths are raised in a culture that reflects Hollywood philosophy that "if it feels good, do it." This is also sandwiched with another destructive myth that says, "I do what I think and know is right." A lot of youths believe they can do whatever they want with their lives without any accountability or sense of responsibility because they are young.

IDENTITY CRISIS

The question today's youth most consistently asks is, "Who am I?" They are a searching generation. They are not willing to accept traditional answers and roles just because "that's the way it's always been done." They want meaningful answers, answers which can stand the test of careful scrutiny, answers to build their lives and futures on. They want to understand themselves and their world; they want to understand their role in their world. They are asking questions about themselves. This internal examination leads

to a search for self, also labeled an "identity crisis." To affect today's youth, church leaders need to know the basics of identity crisis and self-identity.

Psychologists are finding that youth goes through an "identity crisis" as he passes through puberty. The word "puberty" comes from the Latin word pubertas (to grow hair), one sign of physical maturity. Puberty is the doorway to the mystical land of adolescent experience.

The word "adolescent" is derived from a Latin verb adolescere which means "to grow into maturity" or "to grow up." We can understand adolescence by the following: (1)Sociologically. Adolescence is a transition period from a dependent childhood to an independent, "self-sufficient" adulthood.

(2) Sexually. Adolescence is the time immediately following the emergence of the youth's ability to reproduce himself biologically.

(3) Emotionally. Adolescence is that age of self-awareness, when the youth realizes he has an inner nature and searches for an identification of that nature by asking the question "Who am I?"

(4) Chronologically. Adolescence is the time span from approximately 12 to 19 years of age.

(5) Culturally. Adolescence involves entrance into a subculture where the youth will usually identify with and accept value systems of others in his subculture (clique or gang) rather than identifying with and accepting the values of the family.

(6) Physically. The beginning of adolescence is marked by "pubescence" (a period of time of physiological development during which the reproductive functions mature).

Characteristics of Puberty in Girls

1. Skeleton growth
2. Breast development
3. Straight pigmented pubic hair
4. Maximum annual growth increments
5. Kinky pigmented pubic hair
6. Menstruation
7. Appearance of axillary hair

Characteristics of Puberty in Boys

1. Skeleton growth
2. Enlargement of testes
3. Straight pigmented pubic hair
4. Early voice changes
5. Ejaculation
6. Kinky pigmented pubic hair
7. Maximum annual growth increment
8. Appearance of downy facial hair
9. Appearance of axillary hair
10. Late voice change
11. Coarse pigmented facial hair
12. Chest hair

Any of the above characteristics (one or a combination or the above) could be used as an indication of the beginning of puberty. Obviously, puberty is not one of the above events, since in no case will all of them occur simultaneously. Neither do any of the above appear instantaneously. Consequently there is a lot of overlapping in the designation of puberty.

The thought of being "nobody" is intolerable; and the adolescent prefers being a "bad somebody" to a "nobody." However, when a teen is searching for identity, or seeking for a "self," this does not mean he is becoming selfish. He simply wants to become a person. A person should accept himself for what he is; this is self-respect and is not sinful. Jesus allowed for self-respect when He said, "Love thy neighbor as thyself" (Luke 10:27). Rejection of self with also lead a teen not to respect others. To belittle oneself falsely will not lead to an esteem of others. A person can love others only in direct proportion to a proper respect for himself. This is why self-identity is important for teens. Dr. Cecil Osborne says,... A proper self-love is the starting point for loving another person. If we do not love ourselves properly, we can never truly love anyone else; for we tend to

project on our own disguised self-contempt….Self-love does not imply narcissism, egocentricity, selfishness, or a warped self-interest. It does imply: I too, am a person loved by God . . . The Bible asserts that men are what they think of themselves, "For as he thinketh in his heart, so is he" (Prov. 23:7). If a person's self-concept is distorted to either extreme, his actions will be either narcissistic or hostile toward self and others. If he believes himself to be a defeated, inferior, and inadequate person, then soon his actions will reveal these characteristics. Whatever you feel yourself to be at the center of your emotional nature, that is what you really are existentially and your actions will be in harmony with your self-concept. Teens should reject the extreme attitudes of "I am everything!" (egotism) and "I am nothing" (self-rejection).

Restrictions, discipline, and guidance give the teenager a clear picture who he should be. A child who is pampered and never disciplined will expect the same treatment later in his teens and on into adulthood. He does not understand himself nor society. The authority of the parents is but a prelude to the lifelong submission to the authority of school, society, the law, and to God. Adjustment to the control by parents leads to adjustment to society. While the teen finds himself by accepting controls, he must learn to deal with freedom. The freedom of choice also brings with it the responsibility to accept the resulting consequences.

After the adolescent considers God's love and has found himself under authority, he reads God's Word and realizes he is free. Next the teen must consider God's claim upon his life. If man is truly created in the image of God but is separated from God because of his sin, then he must reestablish a relationship with God. Here the teen finds true identity. The adolescent must see himself as a unique person in four areas. First, he is created in God's image and likeness. God was preeminent in creation. Man is made in God's image and is preeminent above the world. Second, man is superior to all creatures of this world. God put man in dominion over all that has been created. Third, man, like his Master, is a rational being. He can think, reason, and express emotion. Fourth, man is spirit. This is not a psychological existence, but a created reality. Man has an immaterial spirit that will live forever. The teen must come to see himself as an individual, uniquely himself, and see that there is something within him that separates him from all other people. That something which God as creator gave to him is his soul.

HOW YOUTHS FIND THEIR IDENTITY

The teen's identification with other persons is one of the basic means whereby he discovers his self-identity. Identification in personality development is not one person attaching himself to a second, as one might attach two pieces of cloth or two sheets of

paper. A teen identifies with a prized person or role model and emulates his basic traits. Identification is carried out in many ways. Some of these factors are:

1. The biological inheritance naturally leads to identification. The boy most naturally will identify with a man, and the young girl will have an "ideal self" with whom she identifies- a certain woman whom she admires.

2. The pressures of society upon children cause them to identify with their own sex. From the moment mother puts pink upon the baby girl, and the young father buys a toy car for the baby boy, society begins to pressure a child to identify with its own sex. The distinct clothes, the different bicycles, and the separate bathrooms pressure the child to identify with his own sex.

3. The degree of love shown a child by the person with whom he identifies influences the degree of identification. The four-year-old boy who attempts to identify with his father is more likely to do so if his father shows love and acceptance to the boy.

Identification is greater if a child's needs are met by the person with whom he is identifying. Identification is much easier when the ideal has a clear role in the perception of the teenager. The older person who is confused in his Christian life will not have a positive influence on the teenager who is seeking to identify. The teenager is more likely to identify with someone who treats him as a person rather than someone who treats him as a child. Identification is greater when there is a degree of acquaintance between the individuals involved. There is a great desire on the part of the teenager to find an adequate pattern of behavior, ranging all the way from etiquette to a broad concept of integrality. The teenager wants to be at peace with himself, and to be accepted by his age-mates yet he is idealistic enough to want to be acceptable to society.

Adolescence is the opportune time for young people to establish a proper relationship with the opposite sex. If this task is not accomplished successfully during these years it may never come naturally again. Close boy-girl relations and a sense of belonging to a group helps the teenager's self-confidence and diminishes his insecurity. Youth leaders must recognize that good relationships are essential to adjustment. The church is a natural place for young people to find companionship. It often provides the greatest opportunity for boys and girls to widen their circle of acquaintance. Young people who date Christian young people eventually will marry Christian young people. The adolescent who dates outside the church will marry outside the church.

The conflict of adolescents with parents frequently blocks easy communications in the problems which bother teenagers. Still the teenager needs adult direction and understanding. The youth advisor then becomes a crucial person in the adolescent's world, offering one of his first and most vital adult relationships. The way the youth worker responds can help or hinder the youth's development or progress toward

maturity. He is a key figure for teenage identification and imitation. The youth is sensitive to the youth advisor's behavior and how he treats him and his schoolmates. He learns from adults-not only by what they say, but by how they live. The teenager wants to be treated as a mature person, whether he is or not. He responds to the attitude of trust and respect. He doesn't want to be told, but wants to find out. It is the obligation of the youth advisor and the church to provide him with this opportunity.

The youths ministry is there to guide young people to mirror Jesus Christ and the word of God. The aim is to present Jesus and God's word to the youths in an appealing way that will want them to look and act like Jesus in all their ways. Youth advisors should

a) lead youths to:

(1). accept Christ as Savior

(2). commit their lives to Christ as Lord and Master

(3). be sensitive to the guidance and power of the Holy Spirit

(4). become church members and loyal Christian disciples

(5). participate in Christian ministries, world missions

(6). witness for Christ, directing others to Him

(7). be faithful stewards of their time, talents and money

(8). use their leisure time constructively

b) help youth to:

(1). genuinely worship the Lord

(2). call in their knowledge and understanding of Bible truths

(3). apply Christian principles to every area and relationship of life

(4). develop habits of personal Bible study and devotion

(5). recognize and respond to the will of God in all decisions

There are four broad categories of teenagers:

1. **The historical teenager**. This teenager has his existence in the minds of many adults. "The way it was when I was a boy" is often heard from adults today. Adults remember the past when they were teenagers and try to understand teenagers today in light of their own actions. Even though adults think their image of the past is accurate, they are subject to error. With time one tends to glorify the past and remember only the good things that were done.

Teenagers do not change in their basic nature or development. The growth patterns, desires, drives and psychological makeup remain the same. But the expression of drives and growth changes. Many adults confuse outer expression with inner makeup. The historical teenager is a "springboard" used by adults to attempt to understand modern youth. The historical teenager cannot help the adult understand youth because outer expression and inner makeup have been confused. The historical teenager is not a real teenager and exists only in the minds of adults recalling the past.

2. **The statistical teenager**. The statistical teenager is one that affects much of life today; however, this teenager does not exist. Many business firms receive substantial income for interviewing teenagers, conducting polls, and arriving at opinions on how the average teenager lives, thinks, and reacts. One company may indicate "95 percent of today's teenagers drink hot tea with lemon." This statistic is then used to sell products and instigate fads, movements and commercial enterprises. The statistical teenager does not exist--he has his existence only on paper.

3. **The commercial teenager**. The modem media of communication present a vivid picture of teenagers. Motion pictures, television and radio present the teenager today on one hand as nearing perfection and also on the other extreme as a juvenile delinquent. The commercial teenage boy is very typical in his appearance. He looks like the latest TV commercial or an ad for a sports magazine. The commercial teenager does not have a real existence. He exists in the minds of the modem-media-oriented audience.

4. **The ideal teenager**. Much is written, portrayed and discussed concerning the ideal teenager. The ideal is supposed to be median between the extremes of terrible and wonderful. He is better than "average," he is ideal or desired. Much is said concerning the "ideal" teenager today. Scholars and psychologists try to understand him. Teenagers try to imitate him. However, the ideal teenager does not exist.

Teenagers must be accepted for what they are, rather than for what we expect them to be. Our expectations are usually called "normal" or "average." If we are not careful this "normal" or "average" becomes the standard set for all teenagers.

The average teenager will fall short of the normal or average standard at some point. Usually the church is very negative and condemnatory, and the teenager who falls short is frustrated (which includes all teenagers in at least one point). Church leaders sometimes cause more frustrations for teenagers than they imagine.

Teenagers must be taught to value their bodies. The teenager must be taught that the "body is the temple of the Holy Ghost" (I Cor. 6:19). His body is not to be abused, nor is it to be used in violation of scriptural principles. The Bible teaches that the body is not to be used as a vehicle for sinful purposes. Avoid any action that degenerates character or destroys morals. The teenager considers their body important.

The body is a vehicle for worship and service. God desires the teenager to bring his body under control of the inner man. This is called discipline. When most of society teaches freedom, the Bible calls for self-control. "If any man will come after me, let him deny himself, and take up his cross daily, and follow me" (Luke 9:23). The body is to be controlled and used as an instrument to serve and glorify God. This is not a negative attitude. Paul said, "I keep under my body, and bring it into subjection" (1 Cor. 9:27). By this he meant the body should not be a hindrance to service, but should become a means of service. The teenager must see his body as a vehicle given to serve and glorify the God who gave it to him.

YOUTH DEPARTMENT ORGANISATION

The youth department shall have a committee for administration comprising of the Chair person, Chair lady, Secretary, Treasurer, Outreach Coordinator, Evangelism Coordinator, and 2 Committee members.

FORMAT FOR MEETINGS

The format/structure of the youth ministry will consist of regularly scheduled meetings, ministry-wide fellowshipping opportunities/activities, camp meetings, prayer meetings, going out to trips, retreats, outreaches, charitable activities and service days according to the Church calendar days of the year.

The model for youth ministry that CFMI pursues is based on the following principles:

Genuine Salvation

The foundation for developing a mature Christian youth is a personal relationship with Jesus Christ. It is the aim of our youth ministry to have youths that are truly born again and filled with the Holy Spirit. This experience begins when a commitment is made to Jesus Christ by asking him into their hearts by faith. After a young person accepts Christ, they must continue to fellowship with other Christians and attend Church regularly.

Hunger for God's Word

David said, 'where withal shall a young man cleanse his way? By taking need thereto according to Thy Word . . . Thy Word have I hid in my heart that I might not sin against Thee." (Ps. 119:9-11). It is important that youths develop such a similar hunger for the Word of God. "Blessed are they which hunger and thirst after righteousness, for they shall be filled," (Matt. 5:6). Young people satisfy this craving by daily reading, studying, memorizing and applying God's Word.

Holiness

When a young person accepts Christ as Saviour, then studies and lives the Word of God and has a desire to tell others about Christ, he/she is able to set himself/herself apart for his Lord's service. Our youths are expected to be striving to live holy lives and such evidence of changed lives is the fruit of the gospel.

YOUTH DISCIPLINARY POLICY

Our goal is to create safe learning environment for our youths. Discipline is not hollering, jumping up and down, cussing, belittling or begging. Discipline is establishing boundaries of acceptable and unacceptable behaviour. Physical discipline, such as spanking, is never permitted.

Please see below for a list of disciplinary standards:

Prayer

Pray for all the young people in CFMI. Have a register of all youths and pray for them by name. When a youths offends, pray first before you take any action. Search for the Biblical position and the Church's position as stated by the Constitution.

Consultation

Consult your Pastor or immediate leader when you are not sure on how to handle any matter concerning a youth whom you deem to have sinned or disobeyed God's word or involved in any misconduct regarding Church rules.

Correction

When there is behaviour that warrants correction, do not hesitate to correct youths and to advise or reprimand them so that they get back in track. Always be responsive and address inappropriate behavior by promptly responding and following through on the consequences of poor behaviour. Consistently correct poor behaviour without any favouritism. We are partnering with parents in developing successful youths. In every circumstance we love youths with the love of Jesus Christ. Always seek to resolve an issue as soon as possible and reintegrate the child back into the group so that learning can take place. This may mean having a meeting with other leaders or even a conference with the parents of the youth to discuss the youth's disciplinary issues and creating an action plan to resolve those issues.

Consistency

Maintain consistency in handling discipline problems. Discipline must be consistent to be effective. Do not threaten a consequence unless you intend to follow through.

Some of the topics to be covered in youths discussions include:

1. My faith

a. How can I know that there is a God?

b. How can I know that I am saved?

c. Why should I pray? For what should I pray? What are ways of praying?

d. How can I help others find Christ as Savior?

2. My Bible

a. How can I know the Bible is the Word of God?

b. How did we get our Bible?

c. How can God speak to me out of the Bible?

d. How can my Bible help me solve the problems of daily living?

e. Does the Bible have mistakes?

f. What are some practical methods of Bible study?

3. My church

a. Why are there different denominations? Which church is right?

b. What are the qualifications of a good church? How can we improve our church?

c. What meaning does church membership have for a young person?

d. What is the meaning of baptism and the Lord's table?

e. Why should I go to church? How can I get more out of it?

4. My home

a. What makes a home Christian?

b. What responsibilities does a teenager have in a Christian home?

c. What things can a family do together?

d. How much freedom from parental authority have I a right to expect?

e. What help can I expect from the church in choosing my wife (husband)?

f. What preparation can I make now for establishing my own Christian home?

5. Foreign missions

a. Are the heathen really lost?

b. Why send missionaries to other countries when there are so many unsaved in America?

c. Is Christianity right and all of the other religions of the world wrong? Why?

d. What is the relationship of the teenager to foreign missions?

6. My life's work

a. How can I find my spiritual gifts (abilities)?

b. How does God lead a person to find his life's vocation?

c. What are the opportunities for vocational Christian service?

d. What are the Christian standards for success in life's work?

e. What is the Christian's relationship to military service?

7. Personal conduct

a. What is the Christian standard about petting?

b. What is the Christian standard about social drinking?

c. What is the Christian standard about smoking?

d. What is the Christian standard about gambling? (Should one match pennies?)

e. What should be the Christian attitude about swearing?

f. What is cheating?

g. How do teenagers overcome temptation?

h. How can I stand up for my convictions when it means going against the pressure of the crowd?

i. How can a teen overcome evil thoughts?

8. Companionship

a. How should a Christian choose his intimate friends?

b. What does a Christian boy look for in an ideal girl? What does a Christian girl look for in an ideal boy?

c. What constitutes going steady? How old should you be to go steady? What can you do on a Christian date?

BASIS FOR CHOOSING TEACHING METHODS

Age of Your Class

The age of your group is one of the most important concerns to you. Have you considered the three basic age groups: 12-14 years, early; 15-17 years, middle; and 18-24 years, late. Each group has its own needs.

1. Early. In the early age group (12-14 years), you will find a tendency toward being together and doing things together rather than individual activity. So you must then plan your teaching to meet the needs of youth as a group. But this group will have a tendency to do things in two separate groups, boys against girls.

2. Middle. In the middle group (15-17 years) you will find them becoming interested in doing things together as a gang. Here you will find mostly mixed groups, perhaps not as couples but as a mixed gang. You will find individuals in this age group becoming interested in those of the opposite sex but still they will do things as a gang if they are planned in an informal way. You will find that this age group is most critical and that their thinking is greatly governed by the latest fashions and what they read. Cliques will become more of a problem, so you must plan your lesson to work away from these cliques and toward a Christian goal. You will find that much prayer will be needed to analyze this age group and to know how to meet their needs.

3. Late. The late group (18-24), consisting largely of couples and college students, has a need completely different from that of the others. You will now need to plan programs along a more intellectual line with a logical aim behind everything that is said and done.